

The Ferdinand Times

VOL. 1 — THURSDAY, OCTOBER 8, 2026 — MEXICO CITY — AS OF 5:45 A.M. CT

YOUR DAY

SpaceXAI said yes at 11:15 p.m.: Friday now holds three real plans, and none of them is on your calendar

Thursday is the plain weekday: Swim, Miami, Discovery, with rain arriving after dark. Use a few minutes of it to decide how Friday actually runs.



Ferdinand, Luma wrote late Wednesday that your registration for Grok Bot CDMX con SpaceXAI is approved: Friday, 10:00 a.m.–1:00 p.m., at Haab Project in Condesa. That joins the Reap x AIBM Agentic Buildathon (5:00–9:00 p.m., already approved) and the GDG CDMX AI codelab at 7:00 p.m. None of the three is on Google Calendar, where Friday still shows Food at 10:15, Miami 4:00–6:30 and Discovery 6:30–10:00. The morning fits; the evening does not.

Today itself is easy. Google Calendar has News / catchup at 6:00, Swim 6:30–8:30, Food at 10:15 and 3:00, Miami 4:00–6:30, Discovery 6:30–10:00 and Journaling at 10:00; nothing was added overnight. The Cursor billing thread is quiet: no new notice since Wednesday's third failed charge at 5:26 a.m., which means it is still unresolved, not fixed. Weather: overcast and about 15°C at the pool, a high near 20°C, and rain chances jumping past 60% from about 6:00 p.m.

TODAY

6:30–8:30 A.M.	Swim After News / catchup at 6:00; overcast and ~15°C, dry for now	CALENDAR
4:00–6:30 P.M.	Miami Warmest stretch, about 20°C; Food at 10:15 and 3:00	CALENDAR
6:30–10:00 P.M.	Discovery Light rain likely; Journaling at 10:00, Sleep at 11:00	CALENDAR

THIS WEEK

- FRI OCT 9** — Grok Bot CDMX con SpaceXAI, 10:00 a.m.–1:00 p.m., Haab Project Condesa; approved overnight.
- FRI OCT 9** — Reap x AIBM Agentic Buildathon, 5:00–9:00 p.m., approved; GDG CDMX codelab at 7:00 p.m. overlaps. Both clash with Miami and Discovery.
- SAT OCT 10** — Free restored-film screenings at UNAM's CCU; Sleep is the only calendar entry.
- SUN OCT 11** — The DNS root changes its key-signing key, only the second time ever.

TONIGHT

Discovery at 6:30, with rain. If it turns into a night out: Rodrigo y Gabriela at Polyforum Siqueiros or Pablo Alborán at Auditorio Nacional. See On the Town.

DUE

Put SpaceXAI on Friday's calendar; pick one Friday evening plan; fix the Cursor card; Telmex by Oct 15.

WEATHER

~20° / ~15° HIGH / LOW

Overcast and about 15°C at compile. Patchy rain nearby through the afternoon, but chances stay near 15–20% until about 3:00. Then it turns: light rain around 6:00 p.m. (about 60%) and drizzle into the night (near 70%). Pack the umbrella for the trip home from Discovery.

FRI	Drizzle on and off all day	~16 / ~14
SAT	Cloudy, showers after 3 p.m.	~22 / ~14

NEEDS A LOOK

- LUMA / SPACEXAI** **ACTION**
Approved: Fri 10 a.m.–1 p.m., Condesa. Add it to the calendar.
- FRIDAY EVENING** **DECIDE**
Buildathon 5–9 vs GDG codelab 7 p.m. vs Miami and Discovery.
- CURSOR BILLING** **ACTION**
No new notice since Wednesday's third decline. Still unresolved.
- TELMEX** **DUE**
Reminders say the bill is due Thursday, October 15.
- GDG CDMX** **FYI**
New: "Probabilidad & Estadística Científica, parte II."
- KAGGLE** **FYI**
NFL Big Data Bowl 2027 launched, with Combine tracking data.

INBOX

BYTEBYTEGO

How Netflix Taught an LLM to Recommend Movies So That You Keep Watching

FROM BYTEBYTEGO · WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 7

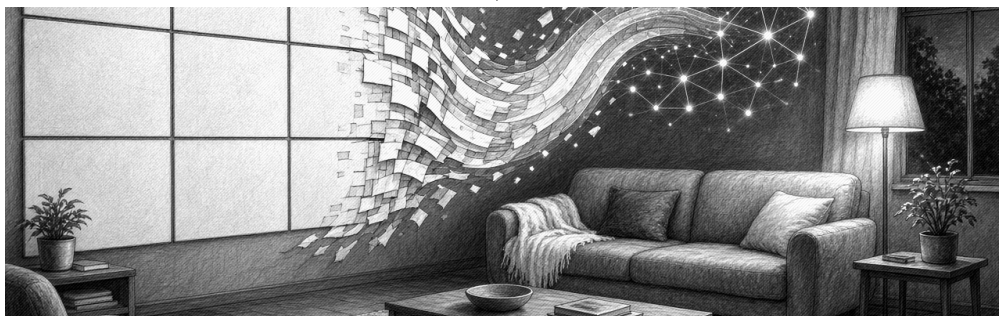
Inside GenRec: Netflix replaced a stack of thousands of hand-crafted features with an open-source LLM it taught to read your viewing history and rank what appears first on the homepage.

The whole job of a recommender is one question: what goes first? Attention is short. If a viewer checks a few titles and finds nothing, the system has failed, no matter how good the rest of the catalog is.

The old engine was powerful but costly to extend to each new use case.

GenRec trains in two phases. First, Netflix adapts an open-source foundation model on its own data so it learns the catalog and member behavior; that base is updated only now and then. Second, post-training teaches it to rank against reward signals and cost targets, and that phase runs often as new shows arrive and tastes shift.

Training data comes from behavior: plays, watch time, thumbs, watchlist adds and abandoned sessions.



EDITOR'S SUMMARY: The clever part is format. Each example becomes a conversation: the “user” turn holds a member’s history, context and the task; the “assistant” turn says what that person actually did next, such as finishing a mystery series and starting another in the evening. Nobody chats with Netflix; the format just makes training easy. Then comes context engineering: tokens cost money, so the team chooses which events are strong evidence and worth describing, rather than dumping a whole viewing history into the prompt. A rare piece that sits right between your two interests, tech and TV.

EVERY

Building a More Efficient Agent: One Cache Bug Was Costing Every 74 Percent

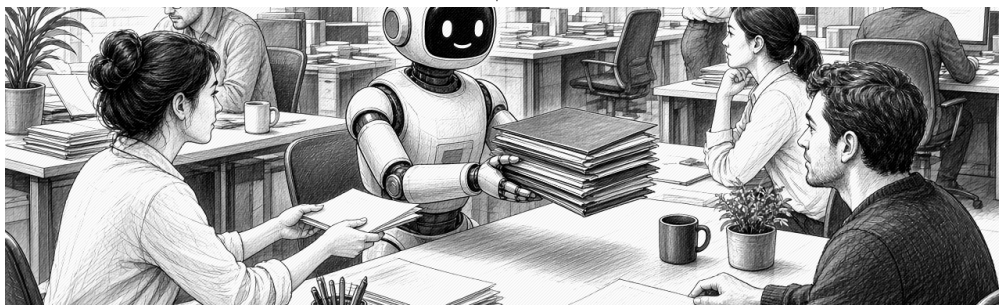
FROM EVERY'S CONTEXT WINDOW · WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 7

Engineer Paridhi Agarwal cut token use across 11 frequent tasks by more than 80 percent, with a model upgrade, leaner tools and one easy-to-miss detail in the system prompt.

A first attempt routed requests between two models. Quality and speed suffered, and costs went up because many requests hit both. “We don’t necessarily need a complex engineering system,” she concluded.

Instead she hunted waste. Upgrading from Opus 5 to Opus 5.5 helped within hours. Tools for GitHub and Linear were returning internal details nobody needed; she rewrote them to return short, labeled results, and the agent now loads full tool details only on demand. That trimmed about 10 percent.

Then the big one: prompt caching, which everyone assumed worked, did not.



EDITOR'S SUMMARY: Memory folder names were injected into the system prompt, and each included the user’s Slack ID, so the prompt differed for every person and the cache never got reused. Giving every folder the same generic name, and keeping IDs out of the model’s view, cut costs by up to 74 percent in her best test. Also in the issue: why Every replaced a bot per employee with one shared company agent (Willie Williams: personal agents belong at home), plus a four-step workflow for using a coding agent to find token waste in your own software.

INBOX

TLDR DATA

An iPhone beat Databricks clusters at analytics, Pinterest built metrics for agents, and Airbnb replays production

FROM TLDR DATA · THURSDAY, OCTOBER 8

*This morning's data issue is a quiet argument for small machines and real traffic: single-node engines are faster than you think, and synthetic tests miss what production reveals.***DATABRICKS VS. AN IPHONE**

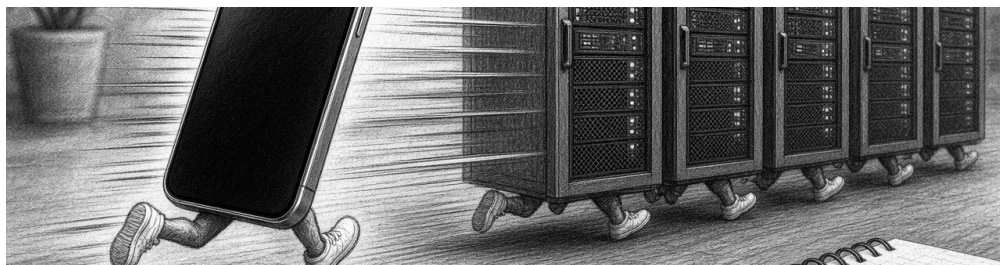
Fivetran CEO George Fraser ran DuckDB on an iPhone 17 Pro against Databricks clusters and the phone won most TPC-H workloads, with far fewer CPUs and less memory. His point: much business analytics never needed a distributed system.

PINTEREST'S METRICS BOARD

A central platform that automates metric creation, checks, docs and publishing. It handles over 98% of experiment metrics, cuts build time from weeks to days, and gives AI agents trusted definitions to query.

AIRBNB TRAFFIC REPLAY

Captures real MySQL queries and replays them in order and on time, catching regressions benchmarks missed.



EDITOR'S SUMMARY: Also worth a look: WHOOP's self-service change-data-capture pipeline for hundreds of Postgres tables, which keeps fast raw changes separate from slower materialization; a guide to "golden-question" benchmarks that regression-test data agents on frozen snapshots inside CI; and MotherDuck's five SQL use cases for Jev, a classifier that returns fixed answers with confidence scores. Over in TLDR AI: Anthropic released Claude Haiku 5.5, its new fast, low-cost model, and a "mathpocalypse" debate continues over machine-made proofs.

THE TOWN

RECOMMENDED

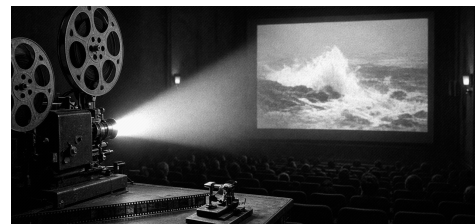
The Pragmatic Engineer: Building resilient systems with Sam Newman

The microservices author on when they are worth it, how to build distributed systems that survive failure, and how AI is changing software work. A good listen for the Swim commute or Friday's cross-town hops.

n8n Agents and the CodePen API v2

n8n now lets you give an agent a model, instructions and your workflows as tools, reachable from Slack or a schedule. CodePen opened a read/write API for Pens, Collections and Assets.

ON THE TOWN

**Restored cinema, free – today through Sunday, UNAM's CCU**

Filmoteca UNAM's 8th Arcadia festival of rescued and restored films fills the Julio Bracho, José Revueltas and Carlos Monsiváis halls Oct 8–11, free until full. Andrzej Wajda's *Man of Marble* screens Saturday at 4:30.

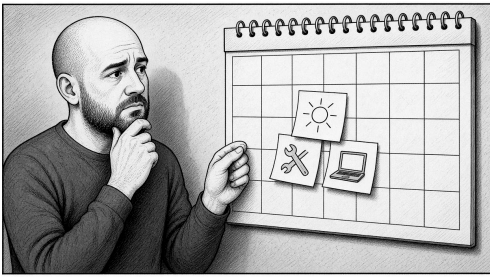
Rodrigo y Gabriela, Miami Horror and more – tonight

Rodrigo y Gabriela play Polyforum Siqueiros; Miami Horror is at Foro Puebla; Pablo Alborán at Auditorio Nacional. Weekend: Of Monsters and Men (Fri, Pepsi Center), Son Lux (Sat, Foro Indie Rocks!), Natalia Lafourcade and Peter Bjorn and John (Sun), and a free John Lennon tribute at Futurama, Fri–Sun.

PUZZLES



Approved, 11:15 p.m.



Three tickets, one Friday.



Condesa to Buildathon, in the drizzle.

MINI CROSSWORD

1	2	3	4	5
6				
7				
8				
9				

ACROSS

- 1 Like on a post, or a thumbs-up for GenRec
6 Glowing bit left in the fireplace
7 Misuse, as of a free API tier
8 Sticky stuff in some 3D printers
9 What Netflix’s ranker must keep up with

DOWN

- 1 Same as 1-Across (word-square twin)
2 Same as 6-Across
3 Same as 7-Across
4 Same as 8-Across
5 Same as 9-Across

HEART · EMBER · ABUSE · RESIN · TREND

DEAR TIMES

I got into all three Friday events. Can a person be in Condesa at 10, a buildathon at 5 and a codelab at 7?

Dear Times, Last night my SpaceXAI ticket came through, so Friday now has a morning meetup, an evening buildathon and a Google codelab at 7:00 that lands in the middle of it. My calendar knows about none of them and still thinks I’m doing my usual afternoon. It will also be drizzling. How do I do this without losing the whole day?

– Triple-Booked in Mexico City

Dear Triple-Booked, Treat it like Every’s token bill: cut the waste, keep what works. The morning is free and clear, so put SpaceXAI on the calendar now. For the evening, choose one room and stay in it; the buildathon is the bigger commitment, and codelabs come back. Move Miami and Discovery today, not at 4:59 on Friday. And pack the umbrella: dashing across the city is faster when you’re dry.

– The Times

JUMBLE

Unscramble each word. Circled answer boxes spell the bonus: what Ferdinand makes across the city in panel three (4 letters).

RAMAD

○□□□□

TNEGA

○□□□□

ROCSE

○□□□□

DIMHU

○□□□□

DRAMA AGENT SCORE HUMID · DASH

WANTED

One Friday calendar, current.

Three approved events seek representation on Google Calendar. Currently listed: Miami and Discovery, who were not consulted.

A payment card that goes through.

Cursor subscription, three declines and a day of silence, still seeking a working method. Inquire in billing settings.

FOR SALE

Databricks cluster, barely needed.

Outrun by a phone on most TPC-H queries. Will trade for one laptop running DuckDB. Serious analysts only.

System prompt, personalized.

Contains every user’s Slack ID. Never cached once. Generic version now preferred by the accounting department.

NOTICES

Department of Internet Keys

The DNS root changes its key-signing key on Sunday, October 11, only the second time ever. Apple’s LG-built home devices go on sale Tuesday, October 13.

Municipal weather desk

~15°C and overcast at swim time; a high near 20°C; rain likely from about 6 p.m. Friday stays cool and drizzly, near 16°C.